

Namiko Dote

Reading Reflection 01

When reading this chapter, I thought it was super creative how Barr came up with so many versions of Pong just by asking "what if." What stood out to me most was the process itself. He basically did a huge brain dump on a plane, throwing out ideas without worrying whether they were good or not. That's something I have a hard time doing. I tend to get stuck on specific aspects, and I have a bad habit of deleting ideas if I don't think they're good enough. So seeing a giant brain dump laid out in front of you like that was really cool.

What I liked is how small most of the changes were. Blind Pong is literally one line of code making the ball invisible, and the whole game feels different. It reminded me of the game Krillion, which is basically the opposite of Jeopardy. In Jeopardy you're supposed to name the well-known answers in each category, but in Krillion you win by naming the rarest ones. It's one small rule change, and it becomes a completely different game.

That's why I think Barr's point about rules being a design material really matters. You don't have to reinvent the wheel to create something great. Fertility Pong proves it too: a bug ended up making the game better, and Barr kept it instead of fixing it. If he had deleted every idea that wasn't "perfect," a lot of these games wouldn't exist.

For me, the biggest takeaway is that ideas don't have to be perfect to be worth keeping. Sometimes the small, messy "what ifs" are exactly where the interesting stuff comes from, and I want to stop deleting mine so fast.